19

“TARGET DESTROYED!”

By the morning of October 27, few people in the Cuban leadership or among the Soviet commanders in Cuba doubted that an invasion was imminent. There was no need for spies or secret information from UN headquarters in New York or the KGB station in Washington to reach that conclusion. The evidence was right there in the sky above Cuba. It came with the noise of US Navy Vought F-8 Crusader airplanes, supersonic fighters that could also be used as bombers and surveillance planes. Since October 23 they had been crisscrossing Cuba on a regular basis, focusing on Soviet ballistic missile sites and military installations.

Operation “Blue Moon,” initiated on October 17 and implemented on October 23, involved pilots and planes from two photographic squadrons reinforced by pilots from the US Marine Corps. They flew RF-8A Crusader planes with three CAX-12 trimetrogon cameras and two K-17 vertical cameras, all manufactured by Chicago Aerial Industries. Flying 1,000 feet over their targets (as compared to the 70,000-foot altitude of the U-2s), the